

This transcript covers the Superman cover and the full Vigilante story, "The Man Who Came Back," from *Action Comics* #50 (July 1942).

Cover

Panel 1

- **Header:** ACTION COMICS No. 50. JULY. 10¢.
- **Logo:** A Superman Publication. DC. World's Largest Selling Comic Magazine!
- **Visual:** Superman is holding up a massive, splintering wooden beam to save miners trapped in a dark tunnel.
- **Superman (bottom left logo):** SUPERMAN.
- **Note (bottom right):** SUPERMAN SAYS: BUY DEFENSE STAMPS! HELP NATIONAL DEFENSE.

The Vigilante: "The Man Who Came Back!"

Page 1

Panel 1 (Splash Page)

- **Title:** THE VIGILANTE by Mort Meskin.
- **Caption:** "He was a swell guy," said one. "He was a rat," said another. And both had the best of reasons for believing what they said about Jerry Harms on the day of his funeral! But the Vigilante—lawman who pits Western wits and weapons against the cunning of big town gunmen—had an interest in the case... and it is the Vigilante who brings back the true answer in this strange tale of "THE MAN WHO CAME BACK!"
- **Visual:** The Vigilante crashes his motorcycle through a wooden wall. In the background, a newspaper headline reads: THE HERALD. JERRY HARMS MURDERED! ALDERMAN BURIED TODAY.
- **Small text box:** Two pairs of eyes read one newspaper headline... and see two separate meanings in the simple words.

Page 2

Panel 1

- **Old Man:** Poor old Jerry... he was a swell guy!
- **Stranger:** You're wrong, stranger... Jerry Harms was a rat!

Panel 2

- **Woman:** I won't have you saying that about him! Jerry gained my son from prison when he got mixed up with gangsters in Chinatown!
- **Stranger:** Listen, if we can go somewhere for a cup of coffee, I can tell you plenty about Jerry Harms!

Panel 3

- **Stranger:** So ahead and talk, but I warn you, you can't convince me!
- **Woman:** I think I can!

Panel 4 (Horizontal Center Panel)

- **Caption:** It is a tale that carries us back to a ward politician's office... the office of Alderman Jerry Harms, in the teeming heart of Chinatown...
- **Spud Corliss:** Spud Corliss to see him! He'll wonder what he wants! Yes, yes. Hide Frank! Show him in!
- **Secretary:** Yes, Mr. Harms. That's the name he gave! Shall I show him in?

Panel 5 (Bottom Left)

- **Caption:** Two strangers and the memory of a common acquaintance, now dead. Between them one can see only the brighter side of the slain man... the other, only the darker... but we are luckier, because as we listen to the elder man's strange tale we can form a judgment of our own!

Panel 6 (Bottom Right)

- **Caption:** Leo Corliss, boss of the biggest criminal gang in the district, enters with his chief lieutenant, Leo Sardi...
- **Leo Corliss:** To make it short and sweet, Alderman. Me and Sardi, here, think you oughta quit helpin' the cops to stop crime in the First Ward!
- **Jerry Harms:** How dare you suggest such a thing!

Page 3

Panel 1

- **Leo Corliss:** All right, Corliss... you win! I'll lay off you!
- **Sardi:** Right, boss!
- **Jerry Harms (thought):** But if I keep going up the ladder politically I'll be big enough to crush Corliss and all gangsters like him!

Panel 2

- **Sardi:** If you don't, it'll be too bad! Eh, Sardi?

Panel 3

- **Jerry Harms:** Forgery or not, it'll send you to prison and where will your political career be then?
- **Leo Corliss:** He's right! If I don't do as he says, I'll be finished!

Panel 4

- **Caption:** And so, as many another ambitious man had done, Jerry Harms, who sincerely wanted to be "The People's Friend," forgot his conscience for the sake of his career... and let us take a look at the result!
- **Caption (Yellow Bubble):** CRIME flares all across the Chinatown sector as Spud Corliss makes the most of his hold over Harms!

Panel 5

- **Gangster 1:** We're sure wipin' out the Crimson Gang! Now Spud will run everything!
- **Gangster 2:** Stray bullets are wipin' out innocent bystanders, too! I don't like it!

Panel 6

- **Caption:** Even Young Stuff, small but courageous friend of the Vigilante, is touched by the spreading web of crime...
- **Stuff:** Spud Corliss is lettin' me be a lookout for his stickup gang!
- **Pete Fly:** Say, have you gone completely daffy, Pete Fly?

Panel 7

- **Daffy:** Daffy, nothin'! We're knockin' off the White Front gambling joint tonight!
- **Stuff:** Take my advice and don't do it, chum! You'll wind up peekin' around the eight ball!

Page 4

Panel 1

- **Caption:** The radio studio where Greg Sanders, the Prairie Troubadour, in reality the Vigilante, is warbling cowboy songs...

- **Announcer:** Sorry, son... the Prairie Troubadours are on the air! But you can leave a message!
- **Stuff (on phone):** Tell him to send the Vigilante to the White Front gambling house! There's gonna be...

Panel 2

- **Gangster:** Gonna bump him off, boss?
- **Spud Corliss:** They say he's really a pal of the Vigilante... we'll hold him for bait!

Panel 3

- **Stuff:** The Vigilante said to call up if I got a line on the Corliss business! I'll give the Prairie Troubadour a buzz!

Panel 4

- **Caption:** A heavy hand falls on the Chinatown Kid's shoulder, and he faces...
- **Stuff:** Spud Corliss!
- **Spud:** So... Pete Sly squealed to you and you were going to squeal to the Vigilante!

Panel 5

- **Caption:** Minutes later, a snorting steed carries the Troubadour... in a new role... through the dusk-filled streets!
- **Vigilante:** Come on, you gas-burning bronc! I've got a feeling the Chinatown Kid has got himself in another jam!

Panel 6

- **Vigilante (thought):** Imagine an imitation cowboy like him knowing a real tough lawman like the Vigilante!
- **Stuff (memory):** Sanders may be a softie... but he sure can sing those ballads of the plains!

Panel 7

- **Vigilante:** ...And then the connection broke... but first I heard him yell Spud Corliss's name!
- **Stuff (memory):** Sounds like trouble, pardner... reckon I better tell the Vigilante right off!

Page 5

Panel 1

- **Caption:** While in the Chinatown gambling joint...
- **Gangster:** Stand perfectly still and maybe we'll let you live!
- **Victim:** Nice game, with plenty of bucks in it!

Panel 2

- **Caption:** Suddenly...
- **Gangster 1:** Spud, the Vigilante's comin' 'round the corner this way!
- **Spud:** Shut up! Who ya callin' by name at a time like this?

Panel 3

- **Gangster:** The minute he comes through that door, give 'im every slug ya got!
- **Spud:** We won't miss!

Panel 4

- **Caption:** But a hissing noose writhes into the room behind the waiting killers...
- **Gangster:** What's that? Sounds like...

Panel 5

- **Vigilante:** Your lasso'n' got the Vigilante here!

- **Gangster:** Gee! I never thought Spu... I mean...
- **SFX:** CRACK! H-H-H-YAH!

Panel 6

- **Vigilante:** I like the color of your nose, buddy! One on the red!
- **Gangster:** YIPE!

Panel 7

- **Caption:** A split second later a hurtling figure of vengeance rides like a thunderbolt into the room...
- **Vigilante:** Yippee! I feel like taking a hand in this gamble!
- **Gangster 1:** The Vigilante!
- **Gangster 2:** It is! Get him!

Page 6

Panel 1

- **Vigilante:** And one on the black, which is the color your eye's going to be!
- **Gangster:** Take him offa me!
- **SFX:** BOP!

Panel 2

- **Vigilante:** Now I'll deal you a hand, friend, and see who comes out on top!
- **SFX:** WHACK!

Panel 3

- **Vigilante:** You'll make it worth my while when I drag you to jail for shooting this boy... and when you hand over young Stuff, safe and sound!
- **Spud:** I'll do any—anything you say!

Panel 4

- **Vigilante:** Cut it out, Vigilante! I'll make it worth your while!

Panel 5

- **Sardi:** That'll hold him!
- **Spud:** Attaboy, Sardi! Let's beat it quick!
- **SFX:** BAM!

Panel 6

- **Vigilante:** Over where? Make it pronto!
- **Gangster:** The Chinatown Kid's okay! He's over at my... er...

Panel 7

- **Stuff:** That's right, they got clean away! And they have more hideouts than a pup has fleas!
- **Vigilante:** And they've still got Stuff!
- **Caption:** The rats... wounding that poor kid Pete, who didn't know what it was all about! I'll never stop hunting the gang that did it—and kidnapped Stuff!

Panel 8

- **Caption:** When the bitter awakening comes...
- **Vigilante:** Hey wake up, you masquerade party fiend! Say, it's the Vigilante!
- **Stuff:** And this is the kid they say acted as lookout... and he's alive!

Page 7

Panel 1

- **Caption:** Next morning... and there is another bitter awakening...
- **Old Woman:** You've got to do something, Alderman! Pete was always a good boy, but you know how crime has grown in this neighborhood!

- **Jerry Harms:** I know all right, Mr. Sly!

Panel 2

- **Jerry Harms:** I know who who is really to blame and I'll save your son from the penitentiary!
- **Old Woman:** I'll never forget it!

Panel 3

- **Caption:** In the District Attorney's office...
- **Jerry Harms:** That's how it is, Mr. District Attorney... I consider myself responsible and I'll take my medicine if you'll let that boy go!
- **D.A.:** I'll let him go, Alderman... but I hope you realize this means the end of your career!

Panel 4

- **Caption:** The astounding confession of Jerry Harms continues to rock the city! Police predict it will mean the end of the terror of the Spud Corliss gang for good!

Panel 5

- **Caption:** And in the Sly home...
- **Pete Sly:** I'll never do anything like that again!
- **Old Woman:** I hope you won't, son... always remember that a very fine man sacrificed everything to save you!

Panel 6

- **Caption:** Terror spreads to the secret headquarters of an underworld czar...
- **Leo Corliss:** We got to shut Harms up before he speaks his piece in court! Riggo, you're my official pineapple tosser...
- **Riggo:** I get it, chief!

Panel 7

- **Caption:** A sinister bundle is carried into the office of the broken Harms...
- **Jerry Harms:** Who are you? I gave orders not to be bothered!
- **Vigilante:** I brought you a present, squealer!

Panel 8

- **Caption:** An instant later...
- **Jerry Harms:** A bomb! But you can't kill me... not till I've sent your whole rotten gang to prison!

Page 8

Panel 1

- **Caption:** And so the funeral of Alderman Jerry Harms is held this day, when our two strangers... or are they really strangers?... sit talking about him over their coffee cups.
- **Woman:** So you see, Harms was still a rat when he died! And what he did for your son was only to ease his conscience!
- **Old Man:** I still think he was a swell... but how do you know all this?

Panel 2

- **SFX:** BOOM!

Panel 3

- **Woman:** Because I am Jerry Harms!
- **Old Man:** You must be crazy! Harms was blown to bits by that bomb!

Panel 4

- **Jerry Harms (disguised):** You forget, Sly... there were two of us in that office! After I grabbed the bomb and tossed it back at Riggo and dropped behind my desk... well, they thought I was the dead one!

Panel 5

- **Jerry Harms:** I slipped out, dyed my mustache and bought these glasses! I decided to start life over with a new name!
- **Old Man:** I won't give away your secret... goodbye... and good luck!

Panel 6

- **Caption:** But what's this? A man at the next table lowers a newspaper and we see...
- **Vigilante:** It's the Vigilante!
- **Jerry Harms:** Yes, Harms, and I want you!

Panel 7

- **Vigilante:** I was nearby when that bomb exploded! I saw a man who looked like you leave... I followed to make sure!
- **Jerry Harms:** But Great Scott! Haven't I had enough trouble?

Page 9

Panel 1

- **Caption:** A boy to be saved... and it's high time we found out how the rough-and-ready Chinatown Kid is faring!
- **Stuff:** Boy, I can hardly wait till the Vig gets here!
- **Gangster:** When he does, he won't be listenin' to your lip anymore!
- **SFX:** ZNNNG!
- **Spud:** Dry up, you two, till I answer the phone!

Panel 2

- **Spud:** Yeah, Spike... you say you got Harms in town? Sure, bring him here right away... I'll fix the squealer!

Panel 3

- **Vigilante:** You saved one boy from trouble... and now you've got to save another! Spud knows that you're alive because Riggo didn't come back... and you can locate him!
- **Jerry Harms:** It will probably cost me my life, but I'll do it!

Panel 4

- **Caption:** Two figures, one grim and one hopeless, move furtively through the dusk-filled streets...
- **Vigilante:** The hideout's just ahead, Harms!
- **Jerry Harms:** I'll be careful, Spike!
- **Vigilante (thought):** The sap thinks he has a chance!

Panel 5

- **Caption:** His eyes that learned their keenness out on the sage-covered plains of the West follow their progress...
- **Vigilante (thought):** The varmints are going into the cellar entrance of that house!

Panel 6

- **SFX (Visual):** The Vigilante's motorcycle speeds through the night.
- **Vigilante:** GIDDIAH, BRONC! IT'S ROUNDUP TIME IN CHINATOWN!

Panel 7

- **Caption:** Stairs weren't made for an hoss, but Greg Sanders is in as much of a hurry as I am!

- **Visual:** The Vigilante rides his motorcycle down a flight of stairs into the cellar.

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Panel 1

- **Caption:** A race against death... a swift and sudden underworld death about to pounce in a dingy cellar!
- **Jerry Harms:** Spud, I came to see you—
- **Stuff:** Look out, Harms! They're gonna kill you!
- **Spud Corliss:** Take a good look while you're able!

Panel 2

- **Sardi:** I've stood all I'm goin' to from you, ya brat!
- **Pete Sly:** Hey! Don't take things so serious!

Panel 3

- **Spud Corliss:** Don't you dare hurt that boy!
- **Sardi:** Says you, squealer!
- **SFX:** CRACK-K-K! HOOOO!

Panel 4

- **Caption:** A rending smash—an ear-splitting roar—and—
- **Vigilante:** I didn't take time to knock—
- **SFX:** CRASH!

Panel 5

- **Vigilante:** —But I'll do it now!
- **SFX:** UGH!

Panel 6

- **Caption:** The thunder of a gun sends the masked lawman reeling backward—
- **Vigilante:** Wha—?
- **Spud Corliss:** Suppose I pick on you for a change?

Panel 7

- **Caption:** The "Vig" turns a complete backward somersault, and his spurred heels rake down the side of the bound Stuff!
- **Stuff:** Cut it out! I'm your pal! Remember?

Panel 8

- **Vigilante:** Knock-knock! Who's there?
- **Gangster:** I wish I wasn't!
- **Vigilante:** Ride 'em, waddie!
- **SFX:** WHAM!

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Panel 1

- **Caption:** Stunned by his fall, the Vigilante seems doomed!
- **Spud Corliss:** The Vigilante is through ridin' for good!
- **Sardi:** You did cut it, Vig—my ropes! Here I come, Sardi!

Panel 2

- **Stuff:** I been waitin' a long time for this pleasure!
- **SFX:** BOP!

Panel 3

- **Spud Corliss:** Come on! We'll take the secret tunnels!
- **Gangster:** Yeah... let's beat it while we can! This pair is too dangerous!

Panel 4

- **Stuff:** Wake up, Vig! They're gettin' away!
- **Vigilante:** Huh? Which way did they go?

Panel 5

- **Vigilante:** Here we go, hunting coyotes!
- **Stuff:** Don't compliment 'em, Vig! Coyotes ain't so bad!

Panel 6

- **Caption:** The beam of a headlight stabs through the mysterious twisting tunnels beneath old Chinatown—
- **Vigilante:** There they go!
- **Stuff:** Right you are!

Panel 7

- **Caption:** And a tornado bursts among the fleeing crooks!
- **Vigilante:** Got 'em on the fly!
- **Stuff:** Just like shooting buzzards!
- **SFX:** SOCKO! BOP!

Page 12

Panel 1

- **Caption:** The end of the trail for the gang of renegades...
- **Vigilante:** Step lively!
- **Gangsters:** Hep! Hep!
- **Spud Corliss:** Oh wotta disgrace! An' I never killed nobody hardly ever!

Panel 2

- **Stuff:** I've got him, Stuff!
- **Vigilante:** I gotta have some fun too, don't I?
- **SFX:** SPLAT!

Panel 3

- **Caption:** As for Jerry Harms...
- **Vigilante:** Not dead, but near it! We'll have to rush him to a hospital!
- **Stuff:** He got shot saving my life!

Panel 4

- **Jerry Harms:** Why not let me really die this time? I deserve it!
- **Vigilante:** I'll see that you get what you deserve, Harms!

Panel 5

- **Caption:** The following day... in a hospital room.
- **Jerry Harms:** You've come to take me to prison, Mr. District Attorney?
- **D.A.:** Not today, Alderman!

Panel 6

- **D.A.:** You're a hero! The Vigilante told reporters how you sacrificed your career for one boy—and nearly gave your life for another! Now you can run for mayor!
- **Jerry Harms:** You won't be needing another funeral for a long time!

Panel 7

- **Jerry Harms:** A new chance! Gentlemen, whatever office I may hold, my first job will always be to crush crime!

Panel 8

- **Caption:** Days later...
- **Stuff:** Golly, things are quiet around here lately! What's a guy gonna do for excitement?
- **Vigilante:** Don't you think you've had enough excitement for a while?

Panel 9

- **Closing Box:** But there are more riding, roping, rollicking adventures in the next issue of ACTION COMICS... see for yourself!